successful campaign in Ahmednagar, Akbar was so pleased to see him that he ‘took the prince in his arms and involuntarily danced’.[21]

Is this what Akbar had prayed for, to have at least one of his sons alive and well disposed?

That Nauroz, Daniyal held great feasts and gifted his father precious gems, but it was the ‘jewel of [his] sincerity’, writes Abul Fazl, that had greater value in Akbar’s eyes. Indeed, the emperor was keen, it seems, to share his power and his pleasures with his only dutiful son. Khandesh was renamed ‘Dandesh’ after him, and Daniyal received, besides, an award of 2 lakh mohurs.

Two months later, in April 1601, Akbar decided to return to Agra. This was partly his amirs’ doing. Once, only two decades ago, Akbar had marched to Punjab after his half-brother Hakim died – and stayed on for fourteen years. His amirs would not risk having their lives and households disrupted once again. Thus, Abul Fazl writes that while Ahmednagar had fallen, the Deccani resistance was only just beginning – ‘things went somewhat backward’ – but much of this was kept from the emperor. Even without news of the reverses, Akbar was keen to march all the way to Golconda, but his amirs ‘increased their intrigues’.

Akbar was persuaded to return, but he wasn’t going to rush the journey. The emperor wanted to spend more time with Daniyal; he thought they might go elephant-hunting on the way. As it happens, however, news of the emperor’s departure sparked insurgencies across the Deccan – the beginning of a resistance to Mughal rule that would continue for over a century. As he had so often given up the sight of snow, the skid of ice under his feet, Akbar gave up the few days of pleasure he had planned with his son. He sent Daniyal back to Burhanpur to bring things under control[22] – and continued north alone.

It would have been irresponsible not to. Besides, Akbar had an insurrection to handle too, that of his own flesh and blood.

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In 1602, the forty-seventh year of Akbar’s reign and the sixtieth of his life, news arrived that Shah Abbas of Persia had made a bid for Balkh – the province that once, long ago, Humayun, his brothers and their cousin